

%userprofile%\Appdata\Local\Microsoft\Windows Sidebar\gadgets in the search box. This will take you to the folder where the widgets are stored.

Registry Hacks

Here are some useful hacks for Windows Vista. As usual, back up your registry before you try them.

- I To change the name of the registered user or company, browse to HKEY_LOCAL_MACHINE\Software\Microsoft\Windows NT\CurrentVersion and look for RegisteredOwner and RegisteredOrganization. Double click on them and change the values
- I If you have a sufficiently powerful machine and love the animations in Vista, you might want to slow them down a bit. Navigate to HKEY_CURRENT_USER\Software\Microsoft\Windows\DWM. Once there, create a new key by right clicking on the space below existing keys and choose New > DWORD (32 bit) Value. Call it AnimationShiftKey and enter the value as 1. After rebooting the machine, whenever you want to slow down the animations, press the [Shift] key before it starts.
- I Encrypting and decrypting files in Vista is a multi-click process which takes a fair bit of navigating. With a registry hack, this task can be done with a simple right-click. Navigate to HKEY_CURRENT_USER\Software\Microsoft\Windows\CurrentVersion\Explorer\Advanced and create a new 32-bit DWORD. Call it EncryptionValue and use the value as 1 there. After the system is restarted, you can get encrypting with just a right-click.
- I Speeding up Flip3D: Eye candy is well and good, but not all of us have top-of-the-line graphic cards to render all the slick effects. This hack will limit the number of windows that are rendered in 3D, which will hopefully let you have your cake and eat it too. Navigate to HKEY_CURRENT_USER\Software\Microsoft\Windows\DWM and create a new DWORD value called Max3DWindows. The value should be set to a number between 4 and 9: higher the number the more muscle your graphics card needs to pack. Try it out with different number values by opening multiple windows and checking out the difference.

Enabling Detailed Status Messages

Vista has a verbose mode which informs the user of what is going on behind the

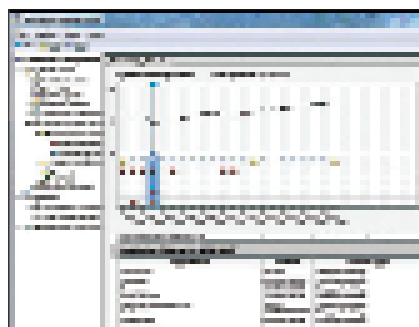
scenes when you are either logging in or shutting down. Click on Start and enter gpedit.msc in the search box. Navigate to Computer Configuration > Administrative Templates > System and locate the Verbose vs. Normal status messages. Right-click and enable it.

Enable NAS Devices In Vista

Vista is still not compatible with many regularly used peripherals, and network storage boxes are one of them. This trick will let you use NAS boxes without downloading any new drivers. In the Start search field, type secpol.msc. In the Local Security Policy editor, expand the Local Policies and select the Security option. Locate the item titled Network Security: LAN Manager Authentication Level and select Properties by right-clicking on the setting. The settings should be changed to Send LM & NTLM—use NTLMv2 session security if negotiated. The incompatible NAS box will work now.

Get Detailed Statistics

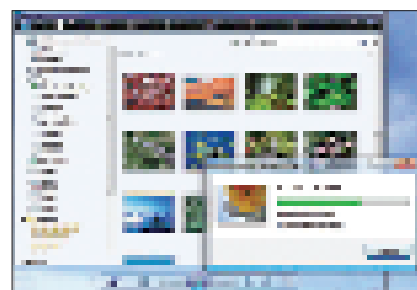
The Windows Experience Score indicates how well your system is running, but it is at a superficial level. Advanced users need to use Microsoft's Management Console to find out the state of the OS. To access this tool, right-click on Computer and select Manage > Reliability and Performance > Reliability Monitor. The detailed graphs show stability indices that determine how stable your system is at any point. Red circles show stages where failure has occurred, with a detailed description on which process had gone belly up. As a troubleshooting tool, this is pretty neat.



The Reliability Monitor provides detailed system diagnostics

Quickly Transfer Photos

Transferring photos from a digital camera involves quite a bit of mouse clicks. Even if the photos are copied to the computer, they remain on the camera's memory card. The Windows Photo Gallery can do this transfer-then-erase function in one go. After the camera is detected and before you start to transfer your photos,



Easily transfer photos and manage camera memory

select File > Options > Import > Always erase from camera after importing. This will clean out your camera memory, essentially completing a cut-paste operation.

Set Core Priority

In machines with multiple cores, most tasks are divided amongst the cores so that the computer can run multiple operations at the same time. There is a performance lag to this system, as running on multiple cores can cause processes to slow down a bit due to data transfer issues between the cores. This is particularly true for programs that make heavy demands on the CPU. In effect the whole computer slows down to a crawl as this affects other programs too. However in Vista you can set a process to run on a single core. Go to the Task Manager and select the process which is hogging all

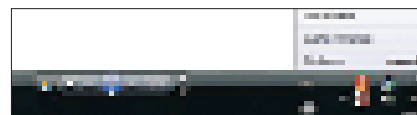


Restrict processes to specific cores

system resources. Right-click on it and select Set Affinity. You can now restrict the process to one of the cores and improve the overall speed.

Get Multiple Clocks

Vista can display more than one clock—a total of three clocks actually. To enable this feature from the Control Panel, click on Date and Time and go



Get multiple clocks in the System Tray

to the Additional Clocks tab. You can set different time zones along with a display name for each. After you click OK these clocks will be visible when the cursor is placed over the default clock. ■